

The Legitimate Role of Labor Unions in Combatting Democratic Backsliding

Helen Eleonora Thomas (née Sam)

4 September 2026

THESIS: Labor unions may legitimately take actions to prevent or reverse democratic backsliding, even if such actions impose significant economic and social costs on the society in which said actions take place.

I. Assumptions and Definitions

A. Definitions

Democracy: form of government that satisfies all the following criteria:

1. *Equality*: there is equality of decision-making power during the process which determines the rules by which said government is governed.
2. *Provisionality*: there are mechanisms by which at least some of the laws and representatives of the government may legally be changed, and thus said set of laws and representatives have only provisional authority
3. *Competition*: all would-be political representatives must compete via elections to determine who is to govern
4. *Checks*: there are checks and balances in place to prevent representatives or governmental functionaries from undermining any aforementioned criteria

Democratic Backsliding: “the state-led debilitation or elimination of any of the political institutions that sustain an existing democracy”

B. Assumptions

Unjust: Democratic backsliding is unjust because:

1. *Public Equality*: Democracy publicly realizes equality, which is itself valuable

This talk also serves as an official coming out. However, I’d rather not focus on this point during our hour together. If you have any questions about what this means, please email me or talk to me at some other time. Also, I chose the name “Helen” before I found out about the famous journalist of the same name, to whom I bear no relation. Consequently, I put my new chosen middle name in here - sort of as an homage to the inimitable Mark E. Smith of The Fall.

Christiano and Bajaj 2018

Anderson 2006, Dahl 2006

Schumpeter 2013 [1942]

Bermeo 2016

Christiano 2008

2. *Rights*: Democracies better protect rights than other forms of government, and backsliding undermines basic liberties Christiano 2011, Jee et al 2022
 3. *Global Justice*: Backsliding negatively correlates with the fulfillment of international obligations (esp. climate-related obligations) Pattison 2025
 4. *Historical Injustice*: Backsliding correlates with the perpetuation of historical injustices against minority groups - an injustice that is worth highlighting as a desideratum of representative democracy is to allow said groups to elect representatives which will pursue their aims and raise previously underappreciated concerns Grumbach 2023, Dovi 2002
- Popular Resistance*: The threat of coordinated popular resistance incentivizes representatives and elites to follow electoral norms Machiavelli 2018 [1531], Fearon 2011
- Joint-ownership*: Other actors besides labor unions may legitimately take actions to prevent or reverse backsliding Kirshner 2014, Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018

II. The Procedural Legitimacy of Labor Unions

1. Labor unions have internal democratic and egalitarian decision-making features.
2. Labor unions require collective deliberation to reach decisions.
3. Labor unions have internal democratic and egalitarian decision-making features, and require collective deliberation to reach decisions. (1, 2, conjunction introduction)
4. If labor unions have internal democratic and egalitarian decision-making features, and require collective deliberation to reach decisions, then their decisions are procedurally just. Young 2000, Christiano 2004
5. The decisions of labor unions are procedurally just. (3, 4, modus ponens)
6. If a decision is procedurally just, then one has a pro tanto reason to follow the decision.
7. One has a pro tanto reason to follow the decisions of labor unions. (5, 6, modus ponens)

III. Labor Unions and Substantive Justice

1. Labor unions coordinate collective action and defend the interests of the worst off. Stehr 2025

2. If labor unions coordinate collective action and defend the interests of the worst off, then they publicly realize justice.
3. Labor unions publicly realize justice. (1, 2, modus ponens)

Christiano 2008, Rawls 1971

IV. Labor Unions and Democratic Backsliding

A. The Pedagogical Role of Labor Unions

1. Democratic backsliding positively correlates with voter ignorance.
2. Labor unions have internal democratic and egalitarian decision-making features and require collective deliberation to reach decisions.
3. If labor unions have internal democratic and egalitarian decision-making features and require collective deliberation to reach decisions, then they effectively aggregate information and educate their members.
4. Labor unions effectively aggregate information and educate their members. (2, 3, modus ponens)
5. If labor unions effectively aggregate information and educate their members, then members will become less ignorant.
6. Labor unions can mitigate the effects of voter ignorance on democratic backsliding. (1, 5)

Pevnick 2024, Chiopris et al 2025,
Braley et al 2023

Hong and Page 2004, Brennan and
Landmore 2021, Anderson 2006

B. Collective Action and Democratic Backsliding

1. Iff there is a plausible threat of collective action enforcing democracy, then leaders are disincentivized from backsliding.
2. If labor unions coordinate collective action, then they can be a plausible threat of democratic enforcement.
3. If labor unions coordinate collective action, then they can disincentivize leaders from backsliding. (1, 2, modus ponens)

Fearon 2011

C. Democratic Backsliding and Public Services

1. Democratic backsliding correlates with declines in public services. Cremaschi et al 2024
2. Labor unions preserve public services.
3. Labor unions mitigate backsliding due to declines in public services. (1, 2)

V. Historical Case Studies

Prevent: Mass union action coordinated resistance to the Kapp-Lüttwitz Putsch

Feldman 1971, Smaldone 2008, Feuchtwanger 1993, Broué 2006

Reverse: FIAT strikes in 1943 aided in the reversal of fascism in Italy

Cecchini 2020

VI. The Samuel Gompers Objection

A. The Objection Itself

1. Labor unions have historically acted in chauvinistic ways.
2. If labor unions have historically acted in chauvinistic ways, then they can undermine public equality.
3. Labor unions can undermine public equality. (1, 2, modus ponens)
4. If labor unions can undermine public equality, then they cannot have legitimate authority.
5. Labor unions cannot have legitimate authority. (3, 4, modus ponens)

B. Unions and Rackets

Racket: an institution which ossifies existing class relations through coercion rather than undermine them

Horkheimer 2025 [1943]

1. If a union acts in chauvinistic ways, then it becomes a racket.
2. If a union becomes a racket, it undermines equality.
3. If a racket undermines public equality, then it loses legitimacy.
4. If a union acts in chauvinistic ways, then it undermines equality. (1, 2, hypothetical connective)
5. If a union acts in chauvinistic ways, then it loses legitimacy (3, 4, hypothetical connective)

VII. *The Autonomy Objection*

A. *The Objection as Such*

1. If unions were permitted to take action to combat backsliding, then they would require closed shops.
2. If a union is closed shop, then it unjustly infringes on the autonomy of both employers and employees.
3. If unions were permitted to take action to combat backsliding, then they would unjustly infringe on the autonomy of both employers and employees. (1, 2, hypothetical connective)
4. If a course of action unjustly infringes on one's autonomy, then it is pro tanto illegitimate.
5. Thus, if unions were permitted to take action to combat backsliding, they would be pro tanto illegitimate.

B. *Assessing the Objection*

1. *A Higher Autonomy - Contra 2*: Closed shops *enable* a separate type of autonomy (e.g., republican freedom) in the workplace
2. *Weighing Autonomy - Contra 2*: Losses in negative freedom which closed shops may incur are outweighed by gains in autonomy in positive and republican domains
3. *Weighing Autonomy in Different Spheres - Contra 5*: The loss of autonomy owing to backsliding outweighs any potential loss of autonomy owing to closed shop workplaces.
4. Thus, per *Different Spheres*, permitting unions to combat backsliding is *more* legitimate than barring them from doing so.

Anderson 2017

Cohen 2011

VII. *The Hobbes-Weber Objection*

A. *The Objection as Such*

1. The state is "the form of human community that (successfully) lays claim to the monopoly of legitimate physical violence within a particular territory."
2. Granting unions legitimacy to act undermines the undivided sovereignty of the state.

Weber 2004 [1921]

3. Undermining the undivided sovereignty of state leads to a war of all against all.
4. Granting unions legitimacy to act leads to a war of all against all. (2, 3, hypothetical connective)
5. The negative consequences of a war of all against all outweigh the negative consequences of democratic backsliding.
6. The negative consequences of granting unions legitimacy outweigh the negative consequences of democratic backsliding. (4, 5, hypothetical connective)

Hobbes 1951 [1651]

B. Response to the Hobbes-Weber Objection

1. Premise 1 is imprecise as it misses the element of class domination.
2. Premise 2 is not necessarily true, as we are often subject to multiple authorities simultaneously.
3. Premise 3 is false, and consequently the argument is unsound.
4. Premise 5 is false, as the negative consequences of undivided sovereignty are worse than the negative consequences of a state of nature.

Raz 2005

Locke 1689